

Telling Tales

Mouthshut.com—an Indian community site—has survived the dotcom doldrums with the support of a loyal community. Faisal Farooqui tells us how



Faisal Farooqui
CEO, MOUTHSHUT.COM

A strong and active online community that supports your Web site during the best of times and the worst is a CEO's dream come true. That's precisely what Faisal Farooqui, CEO of Mouthshut.com, is experiencing.

Mouthshut, a popular consumer reviews site, made a quiet debut in September 2000 without the usual fanfare that accompanied dotcom launches. Slowly but steadily it gained in popularity. But even more popular was its scheme of awarding MS (Mouthshut) points for every interaction on the site, from writing reviews to reading, commenting and rating reviews written by other members. These points could be redeemed for cash. This party however had to come to an end. "We had to make a decision in the best interests of the business that we would not be able to redeem MS points after December 31, 2001," says Farooqui. Following

tag as they had complete control over the system as compared to if they had outsourced the technology and then spent a lot on fixes and upgrades.

Farooqui believes Mouthshut meets the expectations of people because it concentrates on building a product that is "less frills, more value". One instance is, every reviewer can create a profile and interact with other users through the community centre. The 'Trusted Circle' system (which Farooqui plans to patent) allows users to either trust or distrust a review. So if a person has been consistently sending in negative reviews, other users can decide to distrust them and the system filters his reviews out. This ensures that no one can simply log on to Mouthshut and write just about anything about a product.

This CEO reckons that another reason for the strong support for the site is the complete transparency in the way they function, and in their communication with their users. Reviewers at Mouthshut are free to write reviews without editorial intervention except in cases where there is usage of foul language or if the review breaks the terms of agreement of the site. There's also an 'MS Site Status' that informs surfers if the internal e-mail systems are slow on a particular day or if a particular section isn't functioning properly.

His 'Dial the CEO' is an exercise where he takes calls from users who can give their opinion about and advice for improving this dotcom. Farooqui believes this is why people respect the reviews at Mouthshut and keep coming back to it. "Consumers understand that for a good product to stay around it's important for it to stay afloat and earn money, hence it's not possible for us to keep paying."

Farooqui is optimistic that things will look up in another six months and plans to introduce online surveys and complaint modules that will enable users to communicate complaints about a product or a service. He would like to position Mouthshut as the voice of the consumer. "Mouthshut will remain free as long as the Internet is around. That is a commitment we've made to our consumers—they will not have to pay to read reviews." Going by its track record, we can safely assume Mouthshut will keep its word. ■

AVINA LOBO

Both the traffic and the quality of reviews increased—this was despite our decision to stop paying reviewers

the announcement in December, he expected traffic to drop and user activity on the site to be badly hit.

Surprisingly enough, that wasn't the case. Traffic increased and people continued to post reviews, with the quality of the reviews beginning to improve. "We've even had new registrations on Mouthshut and support has emerged not just from users but other dotcoms such as Shubhyatra.com and prizes2b1.com who have offered to pitch in by running contests for us on their site," adds Farooqui.

So what was Farooqui and his team's special touch? Nothing spectacular, actually. They did not spend large amounts of money on high profile marketing and hiring a huge staff like several other sites. They focused on creating good visual appeal and building a robust technology platform in-house. Although this took time to get up and running, it finally worked to their advan-